Grammar & Basics — Word Order, Adjectives & Adverbs, Passive

From snowball sentences to film reviews — grammar rules and L1 tips are in the Reference Section at the back

Phase A — Snowball Sentence Capture

Pick your starter sentence:

A. The cat sat on the mat. **B.** The spaceship landed.

Worked example:

She opened the door.

→ *She **slowly** opened the door. (manner adverb — mid)*

→ *She slowly opened the **heavy front** door. (adjectives — before noun)*

→ ***Yesterday evening,** she slowly opened the heavy front door. (time — front)*

Write down the monster sentence your group just built. Then circle every addition your group made and note where it ended up: at the front, in the middle, or at the end of the sentence.

Your group's final sentence:

_____

_____

_____

How many additions did your group make? _____ Where did most of them end up? **Front** / **Middle** / **End** (circle one)

Phase B — Adverbial Word Order

B1: Time and place

Complete each sentence by writing the expressions in the correct order.

1. She arrived _____ _____ _____ .

[last night / at the station / in London]

2. We had dinner _____ _____ _____ .

[yesterday evening / downtown / at that Italian place]

3. They will move _____ _____ _____ .

[next month / to an apartment / on the east side of town]

4. I studied _____ _____ _____ .

[this morning / for three hours / in the library]

5. The train arrives _____ _____ _____ .

[tonight / at 9:30 / at platform seven]

B2: Frequency adverbs

Rewrite each sentence with the adverb in brackets in the correct position.

1. She goes to the gym after work. *(usually)*

_____

2. He is late for class. *(always)*

_____

3. I have seen such a beautiful sunset. *(never)*

_____

4. They eat lunch in the canteen. *(sometimes)*

_____

5. We can find parking near the university. *(rarely)*

_____

6. She wants to visit Japan. *(also)*

_____

B3: Manner adverbs — where can they go?

For each sentence, write the adverb in every position where it could correctly go. Some sentences have two possible positions, some have three.

1. She completed the assignment. *(carefully)*

_____

_____

2. The band played their final song. *(brilliantly)*

_____

_____

3. He drove the car on the icy road. *(slowly)*

_____

_____

4. The surgeon performed the operation. *(skilfully)*

_____

_____

5. The Fremen warriors crossed the desert. *(silently)*

_____

_____

Phase C — Adjectives vs Adverbs

C1: Adjective or adverb?

Choose the correct form and write it in the gap.

1. She spoke _____ to the frightened children. *(calm / calmly)*

2. This soup tastes _____ . *(delicious / deliciously)*

3. They worked _____ all day without a break. *(hard / hardly)*

4. The weather feels _____ this morning. *(cold / coldly)*

5. He is a very _____ driver. *(careful / carefully)*

6. The dog barked _____ at the stranger. *(angry / angrily)*

7. She looked _____ when she saw the results. *(happy / happily)*

8. The cake smells _____ right now. *(good / well)*

C2: Comparatives and superlatives

Fill in the correct comparative or superlative form of the word in brackets. Watch out: some words may need to change form (e.g. adjective → adverb) before you can compare them.

1. She was _____ *(pretty)* girl of all the girls at the party last night.

2. Pretty?? Try gorgeous! She was _____ *(gorgeous)* one there.

3. Anyway, I think it was probably _____ *(good)* party I've ever been to.

4. Hmm, I disagree. My brother's party was _____ *(good)* and simply _____ *(fun)* than last night's party.

5. But didn't you think the band played _____ *(beautiful)* than last time?

6. Yes, they played far _____ *(skilful)* than the typical "party band."

7. They played their songs _____ *(fast)* than most bands would dare to.

8. Contrast that with last week, when I heard just about _____ *(bad)* band I'd ever heard.

Phase D — Passive Voice

Why use passive? **(A)** doer unknown/unimportant **(B)** action matters more than who did it **(C)** formal/academic register **(D)** doer named later for emphasis

D1: Spot the passive

Read the paragraph below. Underline every passive construction you can find. Then fill in the table: write the construction, identify the tense, and tick the reason the writer chose passive — (A), (B), (C), or (D) from the box above.

The sandworm riding sequence in *Dune: Part Two* was filmed over 44 days by a specialised group of crew members known as the "worm unit." A 90-foot set piece was constructed to resemble the creature's back, and its surface was covered in a sand-coloured elephant-skin texture. Because Villeneuve insisted on natural light, the crew had to return to the same desert location every day until the perfect sunset angle was captured. The scene had originally been storyboarded months earlier, but the physical rig still had to be tested against a soundstage wall before it could be taken out into the desert. Timothee Chalamet has said the sequence was being refined for nearly three months, even though it is shown on screen for only three minutes. Since its release, the scene has been praised by Steven Spielberg and is now being studied by film students around the world.

Passive construction	Tense	(A)	(B)	(C)	(D)

D2: Rewrite in the passive

Rewrite each sentence in the passive voice. Pay attention to the tense. Sentences marked (x2) have two possible passive versions — write both.

1. The board supports the latest initiative.

_____

2. We have informed him.

_____

3. (x2) We will offer him many different options.

_____

_____

4. The police are investigating the matter.

_____

5. (x2) The people gave the candidate an ultimatum.

_____

_____

6. This measure could save the company.

_____

Phase E — The Film Review Makeover

The review below was written by a student and contains errors across three grammar areas. In groups of 3, each person takes one specialist role. Read the review individually and mark every error in your area. Then explain your findings to the group.

A Word Order
Look for: wrong adverb position, time/place in wrong order, frequency adverbs in the wrong spot

B Adjective / Adverb
Look for: adjective where adverb is needed (or vice versa), linking verb mistakes, comparative errors

C Passive Voice
Look for: active voice where passive would fit better, incorrect passive forms, missing words

Review: Dune: Part Two ★★★★☆

Based on a review from The Beacon (University of Portland) — adapted for classroom use

I watched Dune: Part Two last weekend in the cinema, and it completely blew me away. Always this film finds new ways to make you feel something through its incredible use of sound. "The voice," a form of mind control that Paul possesses, sounds ominously and completely surrounds the audience. It sent immediately chills up my spine. The cinematography is exceptional good too. The shots of the desert landscape, with characters staring off into the orange abyss, made me see the desert as a character of its own. The sandworm riding scenes were breathtaking and showed the Fremen's deep connection to their harsh environment. However, the storyline felt predictably from the start. Paul and Anakin Skywalker are the same kind of hero: someone you root for until he gives in to his desire for power. Someone could have written the ending with a bit more subtlety to avoid this problem. Despite this, the film's critique on the weaponisation of religion is really powerful. The Fremen have been subject to political persecution, and their history of oppression has led them to lean deeper into their belief in a messiah. Hans Zimmer's score amplifies masterfully every emotion, and the film has praised by critics worldwide. This is a movie that should be experiencing on the biggest screen possible.

Your specialist area: A / B / C (circle one)

Errors found — write the error, the correction, and why it's wrong:

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

📖 Reference — Word Order

Where do adverbs and extra information go in English?

Three main positions:

Front (before the subject): ***Yesterday,*** *I went to the shops.*

Mid (before the main verb): *She* ***carefully*** *opened the box.*

End (after the object or verb): *He finished the project* ***quickly.***

Frequency adverbs (always, never, often, usually, sometimes, also):

Go **before** the main verb: *She* ***always*** *arrives on time.*

But **after** forms of "to be": *He is* ***always*** *late.*

And **after** the first verb when there are two: *I can* ***never*** *remember his name.*

Not at the start or end: ~~*Always I arrive on time.*~~ / ~~*I arrive on time always.*~~

Exception: *sometimes* and *occasionally* are more flexible — they can also go at the front: ***Sometimes*** *I take the bus.*

Time and place together at the end:

Place comes before time: *I met her* ***at the station last night****.*

Not the other way around: *I met her last night at the station.* (less natural)

Stacking more details at the end:

Duration typically sits between place and time: *I studied* ***in the library for three hours this morning****.*

Two time expressions — specific before general: *The train arrives* ***at 9:30 tonight****.*

Watch out — word order traps from your first language

Dutch speakers

In Dutch, you can put time before place: "*Ik vlieg morgen naar Londen.*"

✗ I am flying **tomorrow** to London.

✓ I am flying **to London tomorrow**.

In Dutch, the verb and subject swap after a fronted adverb: "*Morgen vlieg ik...*"

✗ Tomorrow fly I to London.

✓ Tomorrow **I am flying** to London.

In English, the subject stays before the verb. No swapping.

Spanish speakers

In Spanish, adverbs often come right after the verb: "*Habla perfectamente inglés.*"

✗ She speaks perfectly English.

✓ She speaks English **perfectly**.

✓ She **perfectly** speaks English. *(possible but less common)*

In English, adverbs don't split the verb and its object.

Polish speakers

Polish word order is very flexible — you can put words almost anywhere: "*Wczoraj w bibliotece czytałem książkę.*"

✗ Yesterday in the library read I a book.

✓ Yesterday **I read** a book **in the library**.

English is strict: the subject almost always comes before the verb.

📖 Reference — Adjectives & Adverbs

When do you use an adjective? When an adverb?

The basic rule:

Adjectives describe nouns: *a **careful** driver*

Adverbs describe verbs, adjectives, or other adverbs: *He drives **carefully**.*

The linking verb exception:

After **be, seem, look, feel, taste, smell, sound, appear** use an **adjective**, not an adverb:

*The soup tastes **delicious**.* (not ~~deliciously~~)

*She looks **happy**.* (not ~~happily~~)

Tricky pairs:

good (adjective) vs **well** (adverb): *a **good** show / they played **well***

hard (= with effort) vs **hardly** (= almost not): *She worked **hard**. / She **hardly** worked.*

late (= not on time) vs **lately** (= recently): *He arrived **late**. / Have you seen him **lately**?*

Comparatives and superlatives:

1 syllable: add -er / -est *tall, taller, tallest*

2 syllables: -er/-est or more/most *funny, funnier; famous, more famous*

3+ syllables: always more / most *beautiful, more beautiful, most beautiful*

Irregular: good, better, best | bad, worse, worst | far, further, furthest

Watch out: *fun* looks like a one-syllable word, but it resists -er/-est. Use **more fun / most fun**.

Adverbs ending in -ly always use more / most *more carefully, most skilfully*

Watch out — adjective/adverb traps from your first language

Dutch speakers

Dutch uses the same form for adjective and adverb: "*Hij is snel*" and "*Hij rijdt snel*" both use *snel*.

✗ He drives **quick**.
✓ He drives **quickly**.

Dutch also uses adjective forms after all verbs, not only linking verbs: "*Dat klinkt goed*" and "*Zij zingt goed.*"

✓ That sounds **good**. *(linking verb → adjective is correct here)*
✗ She sings **good**. *(action verb → needs adverb)*
✓ She sings **well**.

In English, add -ly for action verbs. Only linking verbs (be, seem, taste, sound...) take adjectives.

Spanish speakers

Spanish sometimes uses adjective forms as adverbs: "*Habla claro*" (speaks clear/clearly).

✗ She speaks **clear**.
✓ She speaks **clearly**.

Spanish *bueno/bien* parallels the English good/well trap:

✗ She plays the piano very **good**.
✓ She plays the piano very **well**.

When describing how someone does something (an action), English needs the adverb form.

Polish speakers

Polish has clear adjective/adverb pairs (*szybki/szybko*), so the basic rule transfers well. The main trap is comparatives — Polish builds them synthetically (*szybszy* = faster) while English mixes systems.

✗ This is **more easy** than I thought.
✓ This is **easier** than I thought.

Polish also lacks articles, making superlative phrases tricky:

✗ She is **most talented** student in the class.
✓ She is **the most talented** student in the class.

Short English adjectives (1 syllable, many 2-syllable) use -er/-est, not more/most. Superlatives need "the."

📖 Reference — Passive Voice

How does the passive work — and when do you use it?

The formula:

subject + form of "to be" + past participle (+ by ... if you mention the doer)

*Active: The crew **filmed** the scene. → Passive: The scene **was filmed** by the crew.*

Across tenses (active → passive):

Present simple: *Someone **cleans** the room every day. → The room **is cleaned** every day.*

Present continuous: *Someone **is cleaning** the room right now. → The room **is being cleaned** right now.*

Past simple: *Someone **cleaned** the room yesterday. → The room **was cleaned** yesterday.*

Present perfect: *Someone **has cleaned** the room already. → The room **has been cleaned** already.*

Past perfect: *Someone **had cleaned** the room before they arrived. → The room **had been cleaned** before they arrived.*

Modal: *Someone **must clean** the room before 5 PM. → The room **must be cleaned** before 5 PM.*

When is passive useful?

(A) The doer is **unknown or unimportant**: *My bike **was stolen** last night.*

(B) The **action matters more** than who did it: *The experiment **was conducted** under strict conditions.*

(C) It fits the **formal or academic register**: *The data **has been analysed**.*

(D) The doer is **mentioned later for emphasis**: *The film **was directed** by Denis Villeneuve.*

Watch out — passive voice traps from your first language

Dutch speakers

Dutch has two passive auxiliaries: *worden* (process) and *zijn* (result). English uses only "be" for both.

✗ The house **gets built** right now. *(translating "wordt gebouwd" too literally)*

✓ The house **is being built** right now.

Dutch often avoids passive by using "*men*" or "*er*": "*Men zegt dat...*"

✗ **They say** that the film is great. *(not wrong, but passive is often more natural in formal English)*

✓ **It is said** that the film is great.

When Dutch uses "men/er" and the doer is vague, English often prefers the passive.

Spanish speakers

Spanish strongly prefers *se*-passives: "*Se habla español.*" The English *be*-passive can feel heavy and unnatural.

✗ **Spanish speaks** here. *(translating "se habla" word-by-word)*

✓ Spanish **is spoken** here.

Spanish also distinguishes *ser* (action) from *estar* (state) with past participles. English uses "be" for both:

✓ The door **was opened** by the teacher. *(action — ser in Spanish)*

✓ The door **was** already **opened** when I arrived. *(state — estar in Spanish)*

English uses "be" for both action and state passives — context tells you which one it is.

Polish speakers

Polish typically uses reflexive *się* for passive meaning: "*Dom się buduje*" (the house builds itself / is being built).

✗ The house **builds** quickly. *(translating the reflexive literally)*

✓ The house **is being built** quickly.

English passive requires multi-word verb phrases (has been cleaned, was being built) that feel unfamiliar:

✗ The room **was clean** by the staff. *(missing auxiliary parts)*

✓ The room **was cleaned** by the staff.

Pay special attention to the full passive chain: form of "be" + past participle. In perfect tenses, add "been" as well.

Answer Key — For Teacher Use

B1: Time and place

1. She arrived **at the station in London last night**.
2. We had dinner **at that Italian place downtown yesterday evening**.
3. They will move **to an apartment on the east side of town next month**.
4. I studied **in the library for three hours this morning**.
5. The train arrives **at platform seven at 9:30 tonight**.

B2: Frequency adverbs

1. She **usually** goes to the gym after work.
2. He is **always** late for class.
3. I have **never** seen such a beautiful sunset.
4. They **sometimes** eat lunch in the canteen.
   Also accept: Sometimes they eat lunch in the canteen.
5. We can **rarely** find parking near the university.
6. She **also** wants to visit Japan.

B3: Manner adverbs

1. She **carefully** completed the assignment. / She completed the assignment **carefully**.
2. The band **brilliantly** played their final song. / The band played their final song **brilliantly**.
3. He **slowly** drove the car on the icy road. / He drove the car on the icy road **slowly**. / **Slowly,** he drove the car on the icy road.
4. The surgeon **skilfully** performed the operation. / The surgeon performed the operation **skilfully**.
5. The Fremen warriors **silently** crossed the desert. / The Fremen warriors crossed the desert **silently**.
   All items accept mid-position and end-position. Item 3 also accepts front position.

C1: Adjective or adverb?

1. **calmly** — adverb modifying "spoke"
2. **delicious** — adjective after linking verb "tastes"
3. **hard** — means "with effort" ("hardly" = almost not)
4. **cold** — adjective after linking verb "feels"
5. **careful** — adjective modifying noun "driver"
6. **angrily** — adverb modifying "barked"
7. **happy** — adjective after linking verb "looked" (describes her state)
8. **good** — adjective after linking verb "smells"

C2: Comparatives and superlatives

1. **the prettiest**
2. **the most gorgeous**
3. **the best**
4. **better** / **more fun**
5. **more beautifully** — adjective → adverb, then comparative
6. **more skilfully** — adjective → adverb, then comparative
7. **faster**
8. **the worst**

D1: Spot the passive (11 constructions)

Passive construction	Tense	(A)	(B)	(C)	(D)	Notes
was filmed	past simple				✓	doer named: "by ... the worm unit"
was constructed	past simple		✓			
was covered	past simple	✓	✓			accept (A) or (B)
was captured	past simple		✓			
had been storyboarded	past perfect		✓			
had to be tested	modal		✓			
could be taken	modal		✓			
was being refined	past continuous		✓			
is shown	present simple		✓			
has been praised	present perfect				✓	doer named: "by Steven Spielberg"
is now being studied	present continuous		✓		✓	accept (B) or (D)

Reason codes are often debatable — accept any well-argued choice. The codes above are the primary expected answers.

D2: Rewrite in the passive

1. The latest initiative **is supported** by the board.

2. He **has been informed**.

"by us" can be omitted — doer is vague.

3a. He **will be offered** many different options.

3b. Many different options **will be offered** to him.

4. The matter **is being investigated** by the police.

5a. The candidate **was given** an ultimatum by the people.

5b. An ultimatum **was given** to the candidate by the people.

6. The company **could be saved** by this measure.

Phase E: Film Review errors (3 per role)

🅐 Word Order (3 errors)

~~Always this film finds~~ → **This film always finds** — frequency adverb before main verb, not at the start

~~sent immediately chills~~ → **immediately sent chills** — adverb before the verb, not between verb and object

~~amplifies masterfully every emotion~~ → **masterfully amplifies every emotion** or **amplifies every emotion masterfully** — adverb cannot split verb and object

🅑 Adjective / Adverb (3 errors)

~~sounds ominously~~ → **sounds ominous** — "sounds" is a linking verb; use adjective

~~exceptional good~~ → **exceptionally good** — adverb needed to modify the adjective "good"

~~felt predictably~~ → **felt predictable** — "felt" is a linking verb here; use adjective

🅒 Passive Voice (3 errors)

~~Someone could have written the ending~~ → **The ending could have been written** — vague "someone" signals passive is more appropriate

~~the film has praised~~ → **the film has been praised** — missing "been" in present perfect passive

~~should be experiencing~~ → **should be experienced** — passive needs past participle, not present participle